unsatisfactory existences saturated with greed and hatred. In early Buddhism, ignorance is usually of the ***Four Noble Truths*** and thus means a failure to appreciate the true nature of things as impermanent and lacking stable identities. The ***Yoga*** tradition classifies ignorance as a defect of the mind along with self-will, passion, hatred, obsessive attachments and instinctive drives.

The ***Advaita Vedantin*** philosopher ***Shankara*** says that ignorance is the same as the confusion (***adhyasa***) of what is subjective (the true self identical with the Absolute Reality or ***Brahman***) and features of the objective world. This coupling of the true and false manifests itself in our habitual misguided practice of viewing body, mind, senses and will, which are not the self, as the true self. For him *avidya* is misconception and it is the nature of worldly existence. Later *Advaitins* treat it as a cosmic force (***bhava-rupa-avidya***) that is the material cause of all forms of misconception. This power of illusion is sometimes called ***maya***.

The theistic Vedantin ***Ramanuja*** interprets ignorance as ***karma*** that obscures the soul's awareness of itself as God's servant. Kashmiri *Shaivas* belonging to the ***Trika*** cult understand ignorance, which they term ***mala***, as oblivion of one's identity with the universal creative consciousness, and self-identification with one's human life in the world.

Further reading: Gethin 1998; Halbfass 1995; Lipner 1986; Rahula 1969

B

Bhagavad Gita ('Song of the Lord'): the *Gita* is a self-contained episode in a single book of the Sanskrit epic, the *Mahabharata*, one of whose principle themes is